

The humble floppy drive is as good as extinct, and the CD-ROM is treading on similar grounds, with faster and more feature-rich DVD-ROMs all set to dominate the food chain. DVDs not only promise an end to multiple-CD games and applications (and the irritant of 'disk-swapping' that invariably follows), but also bring with them the wonderful world of DVD movies—the concept of the home theatre was never a more likely proposition.

In the field of optical storage, an interesting situation has developed in the market—the prices of DVD-ROM and CD-ROM drives have plummeted dramatically. This has resulted in a situation where you can now buy a DVD-ROM or CD-RW drive for approximately the same price! Also the speeds of these optical drives are at an all-time high—DVD-ROM drives are maxing out at 16X speeds while CD-ROM drives can read data at 52X ROM speeds.

CD-Writers today can burn 700 MB of data in less than three minutes, and a rewritable CD (CD-RW) allows you to burn data more than 50 times on the same disk with reasonable reliability.

DVD-RW, which is still in a nascent stage of development, shows tremendous scope as the ideal data backup solution, with capacities ranging from 4 GB on a normal DVD-R to 23 GB on the new Blue Ray DVD disk. It will certainly take some time for the DVD-R to catch on, simply because the prices are too high right now. But make no mistake—they are the future.

Another category of storage devices are external hard drives and the cute USB Pen drives; ideal solutions for people who shuttle data to and from their home computer and office PC. The Darwinian theory is certainly holding true for Zip and Jaz drives, which are seeing a rapid downfall as CD-Rs become more

and more affordable than Zip diskettes.

So how does one decide on the ideal secondary storage device? A lot depends on what you are going to use it for. A CD-Writer forms an excellent secondary storage device because of its versatility and economy. Falling prices and easy availability make CD-R media a lucrative option when compared with any other secondary form of storage. CD-R media offers excellent data integrity and reliability, and if you back-up important data frequently, a CD-Writer is the best solution for you.

On the other hand, a DVD-Writer can hold huge amounts of data, which makes it an ideal backup and storage solution for design professionals who constantly deal with file sizes running into many gigabytes. Despite their huge capacities, DVD-Writers and DVD-R media are quite costly (and hence uneconomical), but this will certainly change as the adoption increases.

For people who can't invest in a DVD-writer—already launched by LG at a price of around Rs 25,000—but still want a high-capacity storage device, an external hard disk is an excellent proposition. With a USB interface these drives provide fairly good data transfer rates. Moreover, you can take the data wherever you go, so your work is not limited to the office PC.

On the other hand, USB Pen drives are good for moving small document files and other important data that's not more than 512 MB. But the real advantage of these solid-state storage devices is their size—they can be easily slipped into your pocket or used as keychains.

Some models like Creative MuVo and Apacer Steno offer another advantage—they can double as MP3 players. Windows XP doesn't even require you to install drivers, so operating most of these devices is child's play.

Market Overview

In optical storage, CD-ROM has gone out of focus both for buyers and resellers as CD-Writers have made inroads in a big way. The prices for CD-ROMs have plummeted to an all time low of approximately around Rs 1,000. Market sources mention that this is the lowest possible and beyond this point, the vendors would pull CD-ROMs rather than selling at a loss. Eventually in another 6 months or so, in optical drives CD-ROMs would be extinct and only DVD-ROMs and CD-Writers would be available. With prices for CD-Writ-

